

## **James Tobin (1918–2002)**

An economics adviser to President John F. Kennedy in the 1960s, James Tobin studied at Harvard, where he met [John Maynard Keynes](#), and became an advocate of his economic policies. He was an expert on taxation, and suggested a tax, known as the “Tobin tax,” on financial transactions to discourage reckless speculation in the financial markets.

## **Thorstein Veblen (1857–1929)**

Brought up on a farm in Minnesota in a family of Norwegian immigrants, Thorstein Veblen rejected many of the mainstream views of economists of the time. He developed an unconventional approach, combining sociology and economics, which was critical of capitalism, and in *The Theory of the Leisure Class* he described the idea of “[conspicuous consumption](#),” and Veblen goods, which were named after him.

## **Léon Walras (1834–1910)**

French economist Léon Walras studied engineering and tried several careers, including journalism and managing a bank, before turning to economics. He brought his background in mathematics to his study of economics when he was appointed Professor of Political Economy at the University of Lausanne in Switzerland, where he developed his theories of marginal value and the equilibrium of markets.

## **Marilyn Waring (1952–)**

Politician and economist Marilyn Waring was born in Ngaruawahia, Waikato, New Zealand. She was elected to the New Zealand Parliament at the age of 23, but left politics in 1984 to pursue a career as an academic. Her book *If Women Counted* was a milestone in feminist economics, pointing out the way that mainstream economics ignored the contribution women make to the economy.

## **Beatrice Webb (1858–1943) and Sidney Webb (1859–1947)**

Economist, historian, and activist Beatrice Webb and her husband, Sidney, were key figures in the British Trade Union movement, the cooperative movement, the socialist Fabian Society, and in the formation of the Labor Party—a major political party in the UK. Together, the Webbs campaigned for social reforms, including a minimum wage and the establishment of a welfare state. In addition to writing several books together, they were among the co-founders of the London School of Economics.

## **Max Weber (1864–1920)**

Born in Erfurt, Germany, Max Weber was one of the founders of the modern study of sociology, teaching at several German universities. In his essay *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*, he described how the social and religious atmosphere in Northern Europe combined with capitalism and industrialization to bring about economic growth.

## **Friedrich von Wieser (1851–1926)**